

always at home, a warm and welcoming presence in the house 24 hours a day.

As you will see, family money depends on family culture. And family culture depends on family members, old and young. Neither is a burden on the family or its money. They are both the source of family fortunes—and the reason you have them.

FINANCIAL CAPITAL

Family money is very different from the cash that individuals have in the bank. Members of successful Old Money families think of themselves as stewards, not owners, of their financial capital. Since they are not owners of it, they don't feel they have the right to use the money for their own personal enjoyment. Instead, they are just supposed to look out for it, as if it were a piece of heirloom furniture. They might not even like the old thing. They might not particularly like being the custodian of it and regard it as more of a burden than a pleasure. Still, they do their duties.

Personal money has a purpose: to increase your quality of life. It helps you take vacations. It permits you to live in the house of your dreams (if you can afford it). It pays for your beer. It lights your house. It finances your retirement.

Personal money must feel appreciated. It is called upon almost every day to perform some errand or chore. It services the car. It buys subway tickets. It tips the waiter and provides the children with their allowances. It is ready to do almost anything . . . anytime . . . anywhere, provided it is able.

That is the trouble with personal money: There is almost no service to which it might not be put. As a result, it is often stretched too thin and worked too hard. For most people, personal money races from pillar to post, never quite getting a chance to recover its strength. Often, it gets worn out and exhausted. And sometimes, it collapses altogether.

Which is not as bad as it sounds. Personal money is personal money. It's not meant to outlast the job it is meant to perform. For most people, that job ends when they do.